

The Chronicles of Riddick:

Escape From Butcher Bay—Developer's Cut

This was one of the must-have titles for the Xbox prior to its recent release on the PC. The PC edition features a few extras though, including commentary from the game designers on the game's levels and scenarios. *Escape from Butcher Bay* is one of the few games that immediately connect you to your on-screen persona: the beautiful graphics and a first-person view help here, but so does Vin Diesel's wonderful voice-acting, a great combat system and some truly memorable action sequences, excellent

dialogue deliveries and Riddickisms (like Sidhuisms, but much cooler). The combat is truly noteworthy, especially the bits where your character relies on old-fashioned fists-fights and neck-breaks to communicate

his point of view. The game is a perfect blend of stealth, action and black humour which you must play, either on the Xbox or on the PC. After you have, watch *Pitch Black*, then *The Chronicles of Riddick*, and finally the animated short *The Chronicles of Riddick: Dark Fury*—from the same people who gave us MTV's *Aeon Flux*. Then, build a Riddick shrine, and pray for a sequel.

Galactic Civilizations II: Dread Lords

eXplore, eXpand, eXploit, and eXterminate: the 4X genre is back with a big bang in this epic space-strategy. *Galactic Civilizations II* has everything that makes a 4X game a joy to play: the ability to customise a play session to your liking, a deep research and technology tree, and of course a variety of ways in which to skin the proverbial cat. You begin as one of ten available races, each with its own strengths, or you can create your own mixed-breed, customised to your liking. You then pick a galaxy, small or big—the size of the map determines whether the gaming session is a quickie or a long-drawn space trilogy with prequels. Gameplay can span genres—you will build, you will research, and you will try diplomacy, or guile, treats to appease, and every dirty trick that you can conjure up to get an upper hand over competing races. The AI is very challenging as well, and will always keep you on your toes. If, like us, you have been clamouring for some good old-fashioned 4X action, give this game a go.

Star Wars: Knights of the Old Republic

If you have never played a Bioware game before, you owe yourself this experience. If you are a *Star Wars* fan, but haven't played this game, correct that oversight right away. This is it, the quintessential *Star Wars* game. Beautiful graphics, great character models, excellent animations, amazing party characters, the best story in a PC game, (outside of *Planescape Torment*), and possibly the only



game which lets you live the *Star Wars* experience. Saber fights, force powers, battle droids, princesses, Millennium Falcon, and all. You can choose to follow either the Light Side or the Dark Side of the force, and are awarded force powers accordingly. You can also choose from a variety of body armour and light sabers—which can be dual-bladed or single, and can be dual-wielded; furthermore, special crystals can be used to change their damage properties and colour. This epic adventure takes you across the *Star Wars* worlds—from Dantooine, to Kashyyyk—and will leave you wanting more. Fortunately, there is more in the form of *Star Wars Knights of the Old Republic II: The Sith Lords*. The Force is strong with them both.

ALSO ON The PC

- 1 DOOM 3
- 1 Half-Life 2
- 1 Quake 4
- 1 Black & White 2
- 1 The Movies

SONY PLAYSTATION PORTABLE

At first an object of desire, then a portable movie machine (wink, wink), and now the Sony PSP finally got game(s):

Mega Man Powered Up

Enjoy a well-balanced side-scrolling mayhem in this update of the first *Mega Man* game. Beautiful graphics, fast-paced action, cool enemies, plenty of weapons and that Capcom touch.

Street Fighter Alpha 3 MAX

Street Fighter to go! Faithfully ported to the handheld, you have to own this seminal 2D fighting game which is packed with 40 fighters, and comes with ad-hoc multiplayer. Tournaments on the go!

Burnout Legends

You can never play enough *Burnout*—fast, frantic racing, and fast, fitting crashing, two of our favourite things. This version packs in elements from the first three console outings to offer crunchy, juicy delight in each yummy bite. Mmm, now we are hungry. For *Burnout Legends*!

